GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

ISSUE 7

GALLIONS grapevine

January 2002

A fresh start

Team Gallions – Working with residents to make Thamesmead a cleaner and more attractive place to live



Some of Team Gallions with Manager, Tom Broad.

Your landscaping and cleaning service is undergoing a major transformation. We have now successfully brought the staff who provide the services under our direct management so that we can be more responsive to you. But this is just the start.

So far, we have listened to residents through two focus groups. The things that these groups of residents have been telling us have been used to help us design the service. This is on the basis of the current staffing and equipment levels and we will be continuing to improve the service during 2002.

Our improvement plans will cost money and it is important that we get it right. To make sure we do get it right we are continuing with the residents focus groups and setting up a range of experiments around the estates to try out ideas and see what does and does not work.

The team currently comprises 50 staff, including their managers. Their new purple sweatshirts and high visibility yellow jackets mark them out and look very smart. A number of residents have complimented the staff on their appearance and comments like this are always appreciated – we place a great value on the professionalism of this new service.

We are currently hiring much of the equipment and vehicles but when we buy our own they too will be distinctive. In particular, the vehicles will be in the Gallions livery. We are also investigating new equipment on the market. For example in December, resident representatives attended a practical demonstration of a new graffiti removal machine, which we soon will have in action seven days a week in Thamesmead.

Alongside this, we are working with Greenwich Council to agree and provide a consistent standard of service. Once this is established we shall then work in a similar way with Bexley Council. We decided to start with Greenwich because they are launching their 'Pride in the Public Realm' initiative and have chosen Thamesmead as one of the pilot areas. This was an opportunity to improve the over all environment that we simply could not miss!

Hopefully you will have not only noticed the improved general cleanliness but also that special arrangements were put in over Christmas and New Year. As a result the estates did not suffer from the usual neglected appearance over this important time when family and friends are visiting. We had more staff in on Christmas Day, Boxing Day and New Year's

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Customer Feedback

At the beginning of December, we wrote to all tenants and leaseholders inviting them to become part of a Customer Feedback Panel.

We asked residents if they wished to be consulted by us on various aspects of service delivery and requested them to state their preferred method of contact with us. To date 14% of residents have responded, saying that they are interested in being involved. These people will form the Customer Feedback Panel.

The Panel will be consulted no more than four times a year on differing aspects of the services that we provide. In turn, regular feedback will be given to staff and residents on the results and outcomes of the information we receive. We hope that this will allow residents to play an active role in our decision making processes and will allow us, in partnership with customers, to provide continually improving services.

A prize draw was carried out on Wednesday 19th December 2001 for all responses returned by this date. The first prize, a £50.00 gift voucher, was won by Mrs R Fox, pictured above with Paul Coates, our Best Value Co-ordinator and one of our Wardens, Carol Smith.

Four prizes of £25.00 were also drawn. Congratulations to our five prize winners. We would like to take this opportunity to thank everyone who took the time to respond. Those of you who aren't currently, but would like to be, part of the Customer Feedback Panel can join at any time by returning your consultation card or contacting the Customer Response Centre on 0800 83 84 81 and giving them with your details.



Mrs R Fox, front, with Paul Coates, our Best Value Co-ordinator and one of our Wardens, Carol Smith.

A fresh start

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Day and we also set up two bulk rubbish collection points, which proved popular and helped greatly in managing the extra rubbish that comes with the Christmas holiday season.

Rubbish management is a big – and expensive – problem for us. It would help enormously if residents would use chutes or wheelie bins where these are available. Wheelie bins are available free of charge from Greenwich Council. Leaving rubbish around, even in black bags, means that the cleaning teams have to spend time clearing rubbish that would be more usefully spent cleaning and, importantly, Gallions has to bear the cost of removal and dumping. This cost is met from the rent that tenants pay and by recharging residents where we can – but really it is a Council responsibility.

We very much want to encourage residents to let us know what they think about what has been put in place over the past two months and also what they think we should be doing in the future. If you are interested in joining a focus group please contact Jill McNiven or Linda Nash on the main Gallions telephone number.

See back page for your list of contacts

Neighbourhood Wardens are coming to Thamesmead!

A Gallions Housing Association project in partnership with the London Borough of Greenwich

Do you like working with people?

Are you interested in working with the community in Abbeywood and Thamesmead?

Do you have good communication skills?

Would you like to earn between £16,500 and £20,000 a year?

Then being a Neighbourhood Warden may be the job for you!

Gallions, together with Greenwich Council, will be recruiting up to 10 Neighbourhood Wardens to become the eyes and ears of the local community. We are hoping to recruit local people from all backgrounds aged between 18-60 to be Neighbourhood Wardens.

Please note that Neighbourhood Wardens should not have criminal convictions.

These Neighbourhood Wardens will carry out regular patrols in the local area to help people combat anti-social behaviour and environmental nuisance.

Recruitment will take place in **March/April 2002.**

How you can find out more

Try a Course:

To give you a flavour of what a Neighbourhood Warden job involves, we will be running a week-long taster course starting on 18th February. You are guaranteed an interview if you attend the course.

Come to an Information Session:

To find out more about the Neighbourhood Warden jobs or to sign up for the course, please come along to an information session. These will be held on:

Wednesday 6th February	**10.30 am – 11.30 am**
Thursday 7th February	**7.00 pm – 8.00 pm**
Friday 8th February	**2.00 pm – 3.00 pm**

These sessions will be held at the Gallions Housing Association offices on Harrow Manor Way.

Call us:

Alternatively, call Andrea Kilvington on 020 8320 3420 or Claire Irvine on 020 8320 3494 to find out more.



Gallions and Residents Participation Agreement

? Do you want to be involved in decisions that affect your home and the area in which you live?

? Do you want to be consulted on matters that affect you?

We are working together with residents to draw up an Agreement that will clearly set out how you, the residents, can be involved in shaping decisions that affect you.

The agreement aims to set standards around how you can get involved. This ranges from standards for the information you receive to setting out how you can have a direct say in the services that we provide. We want you to help us set these standards.

Over the next few months you will have the opportunity to take part in surveys and small discussion groups. We need to know:

- **What you think of the opportunities for involvement now;**
- **Which of our services you would like more say in, and,**
- **How you would like to get your views across.**

A small group of residents has been set up to negotiate the areas of service that residents will have a say in, and to set standards for future involvement – if you would like to be involved in this group, call Jill or Linda in Tenant Participation on Tel: 028 320 3417 / 3451.

Make sure you get your voice heard!

Prompt payment is vital



All at Gallions hope you enjoyed your Christmas and are having a prosperous New Year.

You may consider this message to be contrary to the one on the leaflet sent out before Christmas but in December 2000, there was a very large increase in the amount of money owed to us by tenants in terms of unpaid rent.

These arrears amounted to the equivalent of a debt of £22.66 for every tenant. December 2001 saw this debt reduced to just over £10 for every tenant. So you can see that the arrears figure is large and we do need to point out that we need to collect this money to pay for the services we provide.

The leaflet was sent to all tenants, regardless of whether they had arrears or not. This was to show that we are serious about making sure that everyone understands the importance of paying rent on time.

We are currently reviewing the idea of introducing an incentive scheme for those tenants who pay their rent promptly and in advance. There will be more to follow about this later in 2002.

Are you missing out on money?

Sometimes it can feel like you need a degree in rocket science to understand all of the tax credits and benefits that are available. To help, we are currently looking to appoint a Welfare Benefits Officer. The role of the Welfare Benefits Officer is to work with all tenants who may be eligible for financial help through the different benefits available.

So, if you are finding it difficult to pay the all of your bills and your rent, this person could be able to help you claim for a tax credit you may not know even existed. We also hope that the new officer will produce case examples to show how people have been helped in this way.

The new officer will be due to start in early March so please call **0800 83 84 81** after then to make a confidential appointment if you would like some help with the very confusing world of tax credits and benefits.



Are you aware...

Are you aware:

- Of the Atrium in Teeswater Court, Thamesmead?
- That, if you are an elderly tenant – even if you do not live in Buckwheat, Shire and Teeswater Courts – you can be an associate member in the Atrium?
- That if you are a member that you will have a subsided trip to the seaside in summer time?
- Of the various groups run in the Atrium by other elderly tenants? These include Bingo, Darts, Handicraft, Line Dancing and a monthly raffle.
- That it is built for the use of the elderly tenants to socialise and meet with their neighbours?
- Of the warden social in the Atrium every Friday at 2.30pm – 4pm? Free tea and biscuits are supplied.
- That the Atrium is open from 9am to 10pm, Monday to Sunday?
- That the membership is FREE?

For further details please contact Cecilia, the Warden on 020 8310 3571 or 07771 540 556.

They say that life begins at forty

We have available for rent 1 bedroom properties in our Atrium Courts. These properties are designed for occupation by people over 40 years of age because of the facilities available and the age of the existing tenants.

Any Thamesmead resident, or anyone who has relatives in Thamesmead, who is 40 plus can apply for one of these homes by ringing 0800 83 84 81 and asking for the Rehousing Team. Please note that homeowners are not eligible to apply.

See back page for your list of contacts

Queen's Jubilee street party

30th June 2002

Are you interested in having a street party for the Queen's Jubilee?

As part of the Jubilee Working Party, which is made up of representatives from Gallions Housing Association, Trust Thamesemead and Tilfen, there is a Street Party Committee that has some funds available to help with the celebrations.

If you are interested in organising a street party for this event please contact Sam Robinson on 0208 311 2250. Sam will be happy to have an initial chat with you and will explain the criteria needed when approaching the committee for funding.

Main decisions taken by the Board at the Meeting of 13 December 2001

- **Environmental Contract** – a proposed business plan was agreed subject to further work on costings and funding. It includes plans for extending the services provided in cleaning and grounds maintenance to improve Thamesmead.
- **Internal Controls Assurance** – The Housing Corporation have recently issued a circular on Internal Controls Assurance. The Board have therefore decided to conduct an annual review of the effectiveness of its internal control systems. Further intensive training will be carried out in 2002 for all staff on the management and appraisal of risk.
- **Tavy Bridge** – The Board have agreed an application for SRB funding to start making improvements to Tavy Bridge following consultation with local residents. The improvements would include safety and security, cleaning of the lake, combating the motor cycle racing problems and helping to prevent drug use in communal areas.

Board Meetings

Gallions Housing Association's Board of Management meets on a regular basis. The meetings are open to all residents.

In order to accommodate any residents who wish to attend, you would need to contact Averyl Richards at our offices, (address below) prior to any meeting to make arrangements.

The dates of the next meetings are:

21 March 2002
13 June 2002
19 September 2002

All meetings are held at Gallions Housing Association offices, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH at 6.30pm.

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phong bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Caroline Wilson (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

Look out in the next issue for the date of the launch of our new improved website...

www.gallionsha.co.uk

FEEDBACK

What do you think of "Gallions Grapevine"? Have you any comments on our service – good or bad? What is your view of living in Thamesmead?

Let us know by writing to **FEEDBACK, Gallions Grapevine, c/o Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.**

Contacts

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London SE2 9XH

Customer Response Centre

Freephone
0800 83 84 81

This freephone number is now taking all calls to Gallions via the Customer Response Centre, this also includes switchboard calls. The old switchboard number will be dissolved in the coming months.

Comfort 2000 Heating
020 8320 3422

Interserve
0800 389 0154